Green Power vs Green Power

Saurashtra's Patidar farmers, including those aligned to BJP, protest an 'unfair' compensation

By **Jumana Shah**

as a right of way over their land under the Indian Telegraph Act, 1885, read with the Electricity Act, 2003. What the farmer loses is use of a portion of the land where the tower base is built. But an overhead corridor also debars any construction, precludes tall crops, makes running harvesters difficult, and causes a lasting hit to resale value.

What they will get against that is a single payment, changed from the original proposal of 40-40-20 instalments. It's the calculation of that amount that is sowing anger. The concerns surfaced in January 2026, when farmers reached out to the government saying only four times the market value will be fair recompense for the long-term damage. They juxtapose their loss against the fact that Halvad Transmission Ltd, the special purpose vehicle of Adani Energy Solutions Ltd which is building the line, will earn from the asset for decades on a single payment.

"An easement is doing the job of land acquisition. We are not opposed to the lines passing through our farmlands, but we need to be sufficiently compensated for it," says Chetan Gadhiya, a Jamnagar-based farmer whose farm is hosting a tower.

The core challenge is how to determine the 'market rate', considering it is a dynamic factor, and varies across locations. The government had initially used the LARR model to fix compensation at twice the jantri rates (circle rate). This rate, the farmers claimed, was way lower than the prevailing market rate.

As displeasure among farmers was brewing, the BKS advised the government to consider the last registered deal in revenue records as the benchmark to determine the market rate, but the state government persisted with its formula. Ramesh Patel, BKS state convenor, concedes the significance of the towers, but says marginal farmers should not become its sacrificial lambs. "The issue could have been resolved in January, but the government underestimated farmers' concerns," Patel says.



ABUZZ WITH DISSENT Pal Ambaliya, Gujarat Kisan Congress chairman, speaking to protesting farmers, Dwarka district

Takeaways

- **Adani green energy park in Kutch building massive transmission line to Morbi**
- **Patidar farmers protest low compensation, citing damage to land; Congress, BJP leaders part of protest**

HARVESTING ANGER

Months passed, farmers wrote many times to district collectors—also requesting a rerouting of the lines in some areas. In vain. By summer, it turned political. Congress farmer leader Pal Ambaliya mobilised the anger. On June 15, 1,000-odd tractors converged on Gandhinagar from Surat, Morbi, Rajkot, Bhavnagar, Kutch and north Gujarat under the banner of the Kisan Congress and Kisan Sangharsh Samiti. A hunger strike began at Jetpar on June 17. Among those who joined it: brothers of state BJP minister Kantilal Amrutiya, BJP MLA from Morbi.

Within a fortnight, the state upped compensation to twice the 'prevailing market value', widened the compensable tower footprint by a metre on each side, and promised full upfront payment. But it only got more muddled. Farmers are asking: who determines the 'prevailing market value', and how? Patel suggests using the most recent deals registered in government records. But Ambaliya says that's an escape route because the real land value is always much higher. Both agree the current formula—a committee to decide the rates—is flawed as vested interests will tilt it in their favour.

The Gujarat Electricity Regulatory Commission claims the matter now needs a standard central policy. Farmer leader Sagar Rabari, meanwhile, points to the severe dry spell in Saurashtra and flays the government's unwillingness to declare drought. Saurashtra's farmers are dominated by the politically heavyweight Patidar community, whose anger had singed the BJP in 2017. A decade on, assuaging them is still key to the flow of power not being disrupted. ■